Fascinating craft of traditional and tribal embroidery

Exquisite embroidery articles like shawls with motifs of cypress and pine trees, the Chenvar leaf, the cherry and the grape from Kashmir, the Rumals (kerchiefs) of Chemba from Himachal Pradesh, the Phulkari (bridal dress) with animal and bird motifs from Punjab, the Zari School of Delhi and Agra, with gold sequins on velvet and silk background, are artistically displayed in three wings of the Lalit Kala Akademi, Greams Road.

It is interesting to see that the goods are as diverse as the country's topography and as rich and varied as its flora and fauna. Almost all types of embroidery stiches practised in the world are present in India and each region has its exclusive forms, motifs and materials. The techniques are peculiar to particular communities of the respective regions, who have kept the tradition alive for generations.

In the rich and colourful world of Indian embroidery, the "Chikankari" of Lucknow and Uttar Pradesh, strikes a cool and delicate note. The outline of the floral motifs is worked on the right side with tiny stitches. The colourful "Thombai", the cylindrical embroidered pipe-like hangings, form part of the unique applique work of Tamil Nadu. Intended for decorating temples and chariots with hangings, some flat pieces are hung behind the image as a backdrop. There are fine pieces of bead embroidery from Saurashtra in Gujarat, stuffed dolls for "Bommalattam", artistic pillow cases, wall hangings, kurthas, kerchiefs, table ware and other types of embroidered dress material.

The exhibition jointly sponsored by the Crafts Council of India, Madras and Madurai Coats Ltd., will be on view till August 8 daily from 10 a.m. to 1 p.m. and 3 p.m. to 7 p.m.

Punjab handicrafts

Nirmal Carpets from Amritsar with floral and bird motifs in pure wool, hand embroidered shawl "Phulkari", in striking colours, inlay woodcrafts like small tables, teapoys and stools, shapely wooden bowls and trays (lacqure ware) with nice designs, plastic inlay and Kalamkari woodcraft, are neatly displayed in the upper hall of Poompuhar, Handicrafts Emporium on Mount Road. The impressive cargo of crafts from Punjab includes exquitely embroidered kerchiefs pillow cases and items of dress material. The wooden toys in attractive colours and trays and bowls, with neatly worked designs are also on show. The exhibition jointly organised by the Handicrafts Marketing and Service Extension Centre, Punjab State Handicrafts and the Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Development Corporation Ltd., will be on view till August 10, daily (except Sunday August 8) from 10 a.m. to 8 p.m.

Fine fabric collages and graphics

From the excellent collection of fabric collages, graphics and 'rumals' (20) by Sonia Dembla on display at the Sarala Art Centre, Nungambakkam, one is able to see the perceptive vision, innate sensitivity and high creativity, of this gifted artist. The fabric collages where the blues merge with the greys and greens, as in the "Bathens" and "Summers" are sheer visual beauties, evoking the static and dynamic aspects of theme. While the imagery is vaguely suggestive, it is rigidly defined by the overlapping coloured fabrics. "Dream" "Hospital" and "11 O' clock" conjure up the atmosphere in the collage, darkness and gloom. The lithographs and etchings (abstracts) in black and white and varying tones and colours, are delicate, sharp and incisive. The exhibition will be on view till August 11 (except Sunday) daily from 9 a.m. to 1 p.m. and 3 p.m. to 7 p.m.

The Hindu/06-08-1982/11